

programming is a vital part of that process and something you need to face. Even if you have access to a team of propeller heads who can build to your specifications, you are still seriously disadvantaged by not understanding the details and not being able to tweak and innovate on your own. Having a secretary does not negate the need for the ability to type. Point and click system building and simplified scripting languages are for consumers and we are shooting for the big leagues here, so buckle up, buy a programming book, and learn how to write some code.

## ■ Settling on a Research Environment

Next thing you need to do is to settle on a primary environment for developing your strategies. This is an area where we've seen an incredible amount of progress since the first edition of this book came out. Back in 2010, when I first started writing this book, the choice of backtesting software was quite limited. There were, of course, as today, hundreds of different software packages, but they were all very similar and all had the same limitations. Most of those packages are still available, and still surprisingly popular among hobby traders, but I would advise you to stay clear of them.

Be careful in screening the available software solutions and make sure to pick a platform which is really up for the task. If you come from the hobby side of trading, you're likely working with retail-oriented technical analysis software, such as MetaStock, TradeStation, TradeSignal, MetaTrader, or WealthLab. There are so many of these, and they all have one thing in common. They are simplistic, outdated, and will greatly limit your creativity. The worst are those that use proprietary scripting languages. Those are aimed at people who don't take trading seriously enough to bother learning proper tech. Luckily, there is no more need for any of these old software packages or their proprietary scripting languages. Big boy tools have become readily available for everyone.

A few of these retail packages use C# or similar open languages to construct trading strategies, and while those are a little less restrictive than the rest, they still tend to be quite limited in the end. The fact of the matter is that any backtest environment made by someone else will be limiting, one way or another. Unless you want to construct your own backtester, all you can do is to pick a software package which best fits your needs and opens the most possibilities to get creative.